United States that had become isolated in the hemisphere, with leftist parties winning elections from Chile, Brazil and Argentina to Nicaragua, and Venezuela's Hugo Chávez claiming the mantle of continuing the Cuban example. Venezuela also had something the Cubans desperately needed: oil.

Chávez signed an initial five-year agreement to sell oil to Cuba at controlled prices – in part in exchange for medical and other services – in 2000. The deal was expended in December, 2004, when Chávez and Castro launched the Bolivarian Alternative for Latin America and the Caribbean (Alternativa Bolivariana para América Latina y el Caribe), an alternative, socialist model for economic integration in the Americas. The ALBA offered a direct challenge to the neoliberal, capitalist integration proposed by President Bush in the Free Trade Area of the Americas or FTAA. The initial accord was a petroleum-for-doctors agreement between Cuba and Venezuela: in exchange for close to 100,000 barrels of subsidized petroleum a day, Cuba would provide 30,000 health professionals for Venezuela's Barrio Adentro program, and train tens of thousands of Venezuelans in Cuba's medical schools and in Venezuela. Barrio Adentro follows the Cuban model of providing comprehensive health services, at no cost, in poor and marginal neighborhoods. In 2006 the program was expanded to include Bolivia, where Venezuela funded a Cuban program to send doctors and develop medical facilities.[41] By 2007, one analyst suggested that Venezuela was "approaching the role of great subsidizer that the Soviet Union had played in 1960–2000."[42]

Cuba after Fidel

In the summer of 2006, a 79-year-old Fidel Castro announced that, due to illness, he was temporarily ceding the presidency to the First Vice President of the country, his brother Raúl. In February of 2008, he declared that he would not seek re-election when his term expired a few days later. The National Assembly unanimously chose Raúl Castro to succeed Fidel as President.